Liturgical Notes on the Solemn Pontifical Mass of the Rite of Lyon

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Introduction

In the Roman Catholic Church, there are different liturgical rites. For example, the current liturgical rite used by the Catholic Church is the Roman Rite, which consists of the Ordinary Form (Novus Ordo) and the Extraordinary Form (Tridentine Rite). The Roman Rite is part of the Western or Latin rite. However, there are various liturgical rites within the Latin liturgical rite. For instance, in Milan, the Ambrosian Rite is used, and in Lyon, France, the Lyonese Rite is observed.

Today, I will focus on the Mass of Catechumens in the solemn pontifical form of the Lyonese Rite. The Lyonese Rite has always intrigued me, and it is said that some of its features bear similarities to the ancient papal liturgy, as described in the Ordo Romanus Primus.

Terce and Vesting of the Archbishop

To begin with, a brief mention might be made to note that at the Mass of the Archbishop in the Primatial Church the office of Terce was always sung immediately preceding Mass, intoned by the archbishop who would then retire to vest in the sacristy while it was being sung.

The Procession

In describing the procession of the Pontifical Mass of the Lyonese rite, Archdale King describes 36 individuals as taking part in this solemn entry, which occurs during the singing of the introit. The procession is in this order:

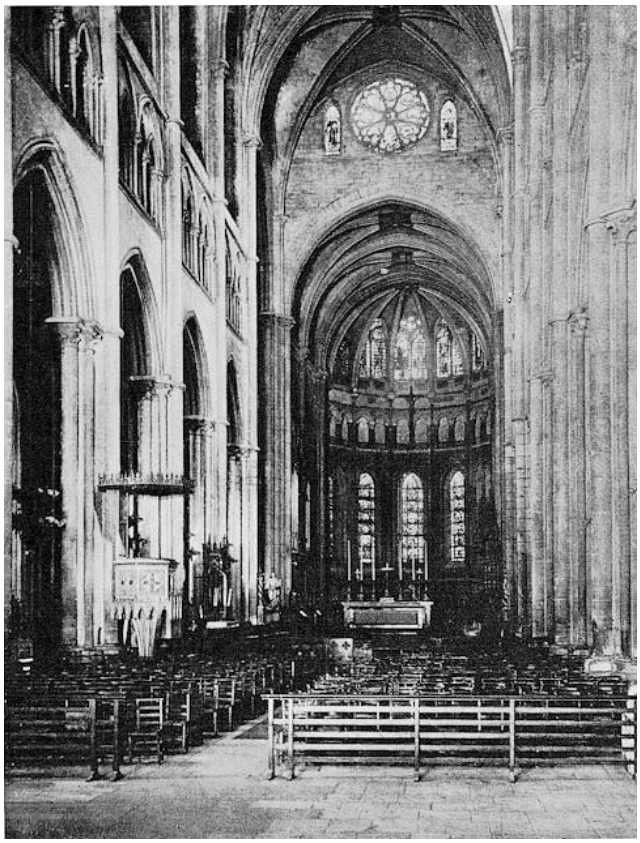
- Seven acolytes in red cassocks with trains and girded albs carrying candles;
- Crucifer and crozier-bearer in copes;
- Seven subdeacons in tunicles (six "induti" subdeacons and the "canon subdeacon" bearing the archepiscopal cross);
- Seven deacons in dalmatics (with the "canon deacon" holding the crozier);
- Six "concelebrant" priests in chasubles (what this means will be covered in part II);
- Two priests in copes holding the gremial, with Archbishop between;
- Trainbearer for the primate;
- Four insignia bearers - book, bugia, mitre, maniple.

In addition to these are the "suisse" and macebearer who head of the procession[1].

Lest it be missed, it would be worth noting here that within this mix we see the number seven figure prominently: Seven acolytes; seven subdeacons; seven deacons and, inclusive of the archbishop himself with his six assistant priests, seven priests.

A Word about the Altar and Sanctuary of the Primatial Church

According to King, inside that space delineated by the balustrade of the high altar was what the Lyonese referred to as the "holy of holies". The balustrade had three doors: the "holy door" reserved for the use of the archbishop (or officiating canon outside pontifical Mass), and two side doors for use of the other sacred ministers. King tells us that in the period of its loss and prior to the restoration of this screen in 1936, it was symbolically and ceremonially represented by a carpet -- something which will be seen in the photographs below[2].



The high altar of the primatial cathedral in the period prior to its renovation in the 1930's

[1] See *Notes on the Catholic Liturgies*, p. 130
[2] See *Liturgies of the Primatial Sees*, p. 130

The 20th century high altar. Aside from the restoration of the balustrade, one can see the evident influence here of the twentieth century liturgical movement, including its fixation on shorter candles and candlesticks

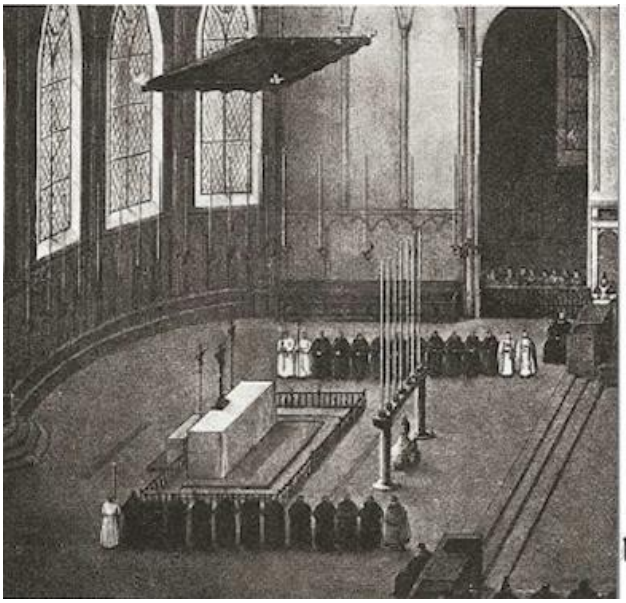
The primatial cathedral as seen today

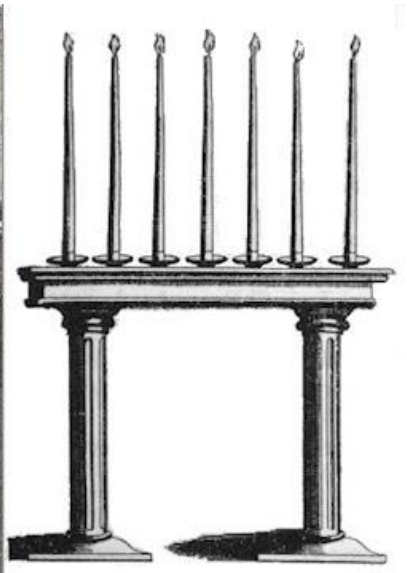
One might also note an object seen on the altar. Archdale King explains: "A cushion of the liturgical colour, on which lies the textus or gospel-book, is placed in the middle of the altar for Mass on semidoubles (and over). It is removed to the credence when the book has been kissed at the conclusion of the gospel." (Ibid., p. 32) While just barely visible, it is also worth noting that the Lyonese custom for the middle altar card was that it be in the form of a triptych, and further, no cards were found at the sides of the altar. (Ibid.)

Mention should also be given to the smaller altar seen directly behind the high altar. This is the altar of St. Speratus, which also functioned as a kind of credence for solemn Masses.

A view of the pre-1936 high altar as seen from the choir; you are seeing the high altar from the back, and you can see the altar of St. Speratus

Historically, prior to 1748, before the high altar stood the ratelier, a great candelabrum which had seven candles, one of which burnt all the time. The others were for the various liturgical functions.



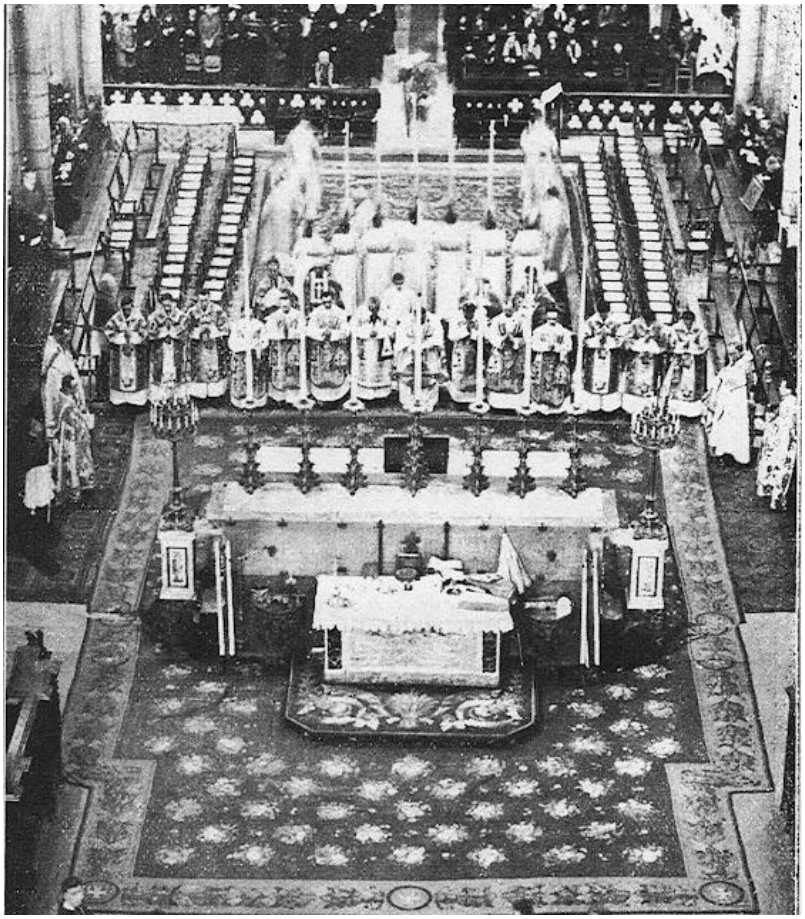


Much more could be said about some of the ceremonial which surrounded these elements or the ceremonial implications of their removal, but we shall let that suffice and continue with our consideration of the Pontifical Mass.

Preparatory Prayers

After the solemn procession we come to the preparatory prayers at the foot of the altar. The seven subdeacons would take their position in the lower part of the choir until the Gloria and the seven acolytes would place their seven candlesticks within the chancel near the sanctuary in a line, and then stood and faced each another with their arms crossed over their breasts.

The assistant priests and the deacons stand in a line on either side of the primate for the preparatory prayers.

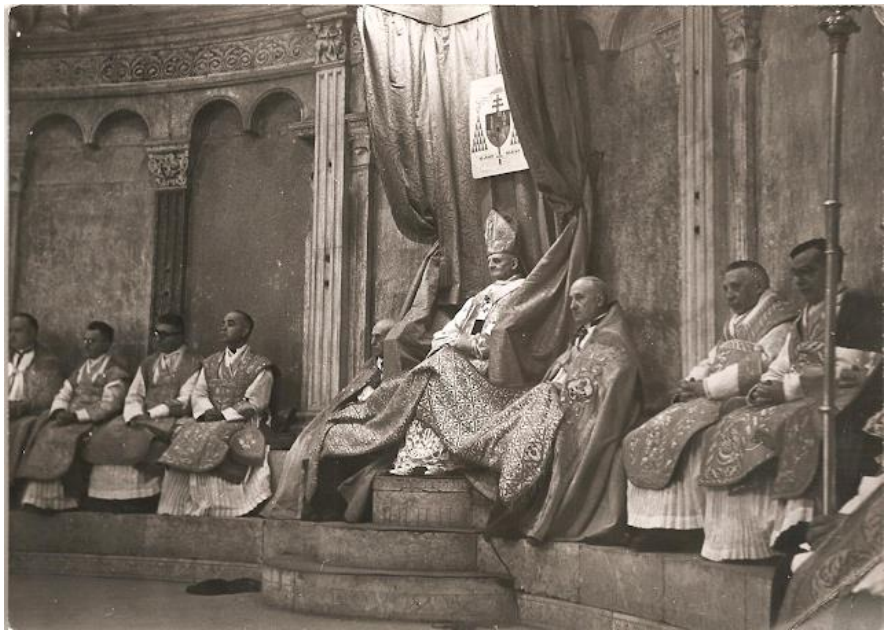


The Confiteor as seen in the arrangement of the Primatial Church on Holy Thursday 1934, taken from behind the high altar looking toward the nave. One will note the line of assistant priests and deacons, and one can also see the acolytes behind with their seven candles still in their hands as well as the subdeacons proceeding to their spots

Following the prayers at the foot of the altar, the archbishop and his six assistant priests go to the altar. The archbishop goes to the centre, and the assistant priests to the sides of the altar, kissing it at the same time as the archbishop (who himself kisses the altar and then also the gospel book that is placed on the cushion).

Kyrie and Gloria

Unlike the usual Roman rite, the altar is not incensed at this point -- though King mentions two standing bowls of incense near the altar. The Archbishop proceeds to his throne which is located within the apse directly behind the high altar, his assistant priests are seated around him.



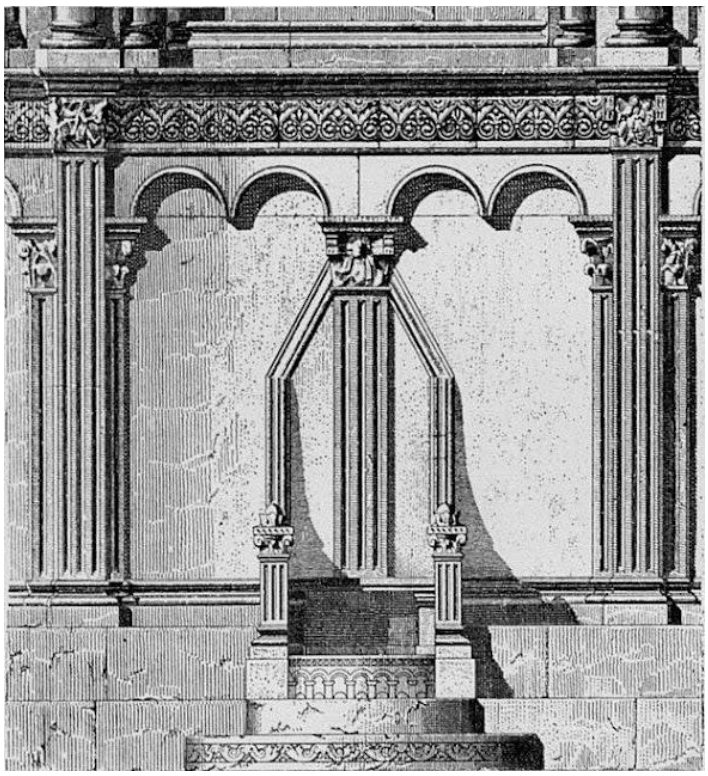
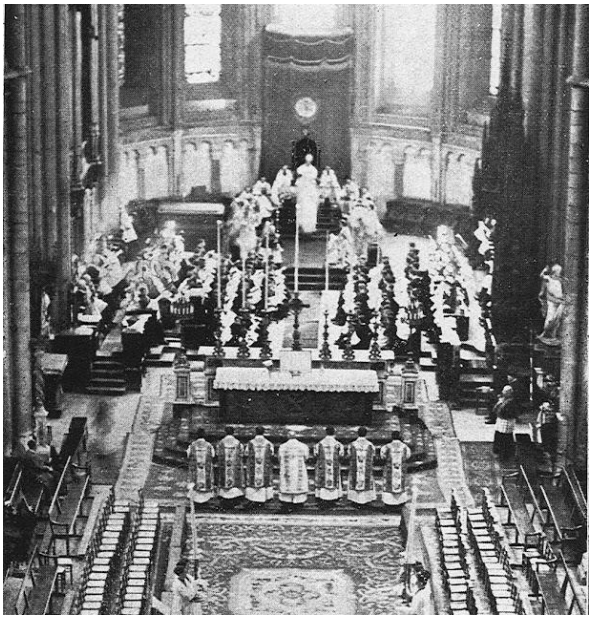


Illustration showing an unobstructed view of the cathedra

The introit is prayed, and Kyrie sung, followed by Gloria. While Gloria (and collects), the seven acolytes again take up their candles.

During all of this, the seven deacons remain in a line facing the altar, "to represent the seven angels who stand constantly before the throne of God" (as La Messe Pontificale Lyonnaise describes it).



The seven deacons lined up facing the altar, the seven acolytes holding their candles and the Archbishop seated on the primatial throne, surrounded by his assistant priests

During the Collect

Readings and "Administration"

After this comes the Epistle which is read by the subdeacon while seated, and with an assistant subdeacon holding the book before him on a cushion.

Following the Epistle and while the gradual is being sung, comes the Lyons equivalent of the praegustatio ceremony, called the "administration". This took place in a side chapel.

Administration at the altar of Notre-Dame du Haut-Done

This ceremony involved the tasting of the wine and is described by King accordingly:

> The participants in the ceremony include the acolytes, subdeacons, deacons, a priest in a cope, the first 'perpetual', another in a mozetta, and the sacristan... The senior subdeacon carries the empty chalice with the paten and host, covered with a veil (pavillon); the senior deacon, the cruet of wine raised in his right hand' while the priest in mozetta brings the burse and corporal. On arrival in the chapel, the acolytes and ministers form two lines, with the senior acolyte in the middle near the entrance. The priest in the corporal goes up to the altar, where he unfolds the corporal, places the vessels on it, and,

> extending his hands over the host, says: Dixit Jesus discipulis suis, etc. The deacon then presents the wine, which the manilier tastes[3]...

Once the wine had been tasted, it would be poured into the chalice and brought back to the altar of St. Speratus. Water will then be added. All of this occurs prior to the Gospel.

The Gospel is proclaimed, and at both its beginning and conclusion, the subdeacon incenses the cross three times. Prior to the removal of the rood screen, the gospel was proclaimed from the rood loft.

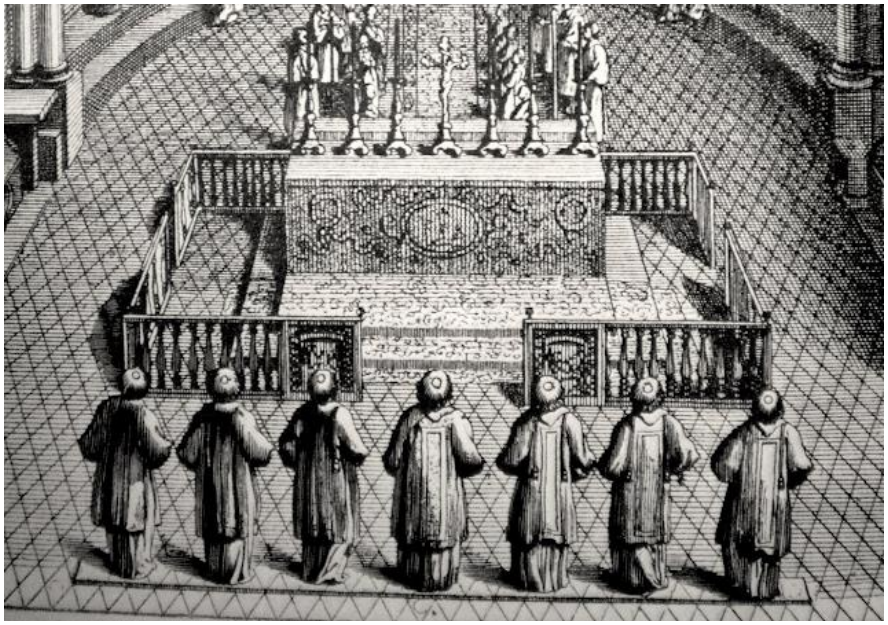
After the veneration of the gospel book, the Creed is then said.

The Offertory

At the conclusion of the Credo two acolytes who kneel before the Archbishop at the throne who, after having removed his pontifical gloves, purifies his fingers. The pontifical gloves that he has removed are taken to the altar on a tray and set on it by a minor cleric (who wears a white cassock with long train and white shoes).

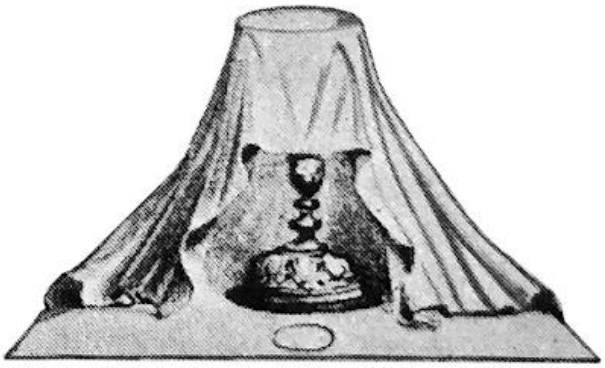
At the conclusion of the purification of his fingers, the archbishop is led by the six priests in chasubles to the altar. At the foot of the altar his mitre is removed, and he ascends to the altar through what is called the "holy door" waiting for the bread and wine to be brought to the altar. It is at this point that we should mention the balustrade that is set around the primatial altar. It has three 'gates' (or openings); a central one called the "holy door" through which only the archbishop may proceed (or in non-pontifical solemn Masses in the cathedral, the celebrant), and then a door one each side; one of the epistle sides and one on the gospel side. Though these the other sacred ministers enter the area of the altar which they call the "holy of holies" (coming with clear reference to the Temple).

[3] See Liturgies of the Primatial Sees, p. 109



The seven acolytes remain standing facing the altar in a line and the six concelebrant priests proceed to the altar of St. Speratus, located behind the high altar, where they receive from the Ceremoniere the hosts that will be consecrated at the Mass. At the same time, the Canon-Subdeacon carries the chalice to the altar and presents it to the Canon-Deacon who in turn presents it to the archbishop. The six priests now proceed to the altar with the hosts to be consecrated at the Mass in hand. As they present the hosts to the primate, they kiss his episcopal ring and then genuflect toward the archbishop. The archbishop then places these hosts brought to him in the ciboria found on the great corporal on the altar.

The archbishop now takes the chalice in hand, with the paten still laid on top of it (as is seen in some other Latin liturgical rites such as the Dominican rite) and prays the offertory prayer. The archbishop then hands the paten to the Canon-Deacon who in turn gives it to the Canon-Subdeacon who conceals it in his maniple (not the humeral veil as is the case in the Roman rite) and takes up a place seated behind the high altar. The archbishop then covers the chalice with the back part of the large corporal that is laid out on the centre of the altar.



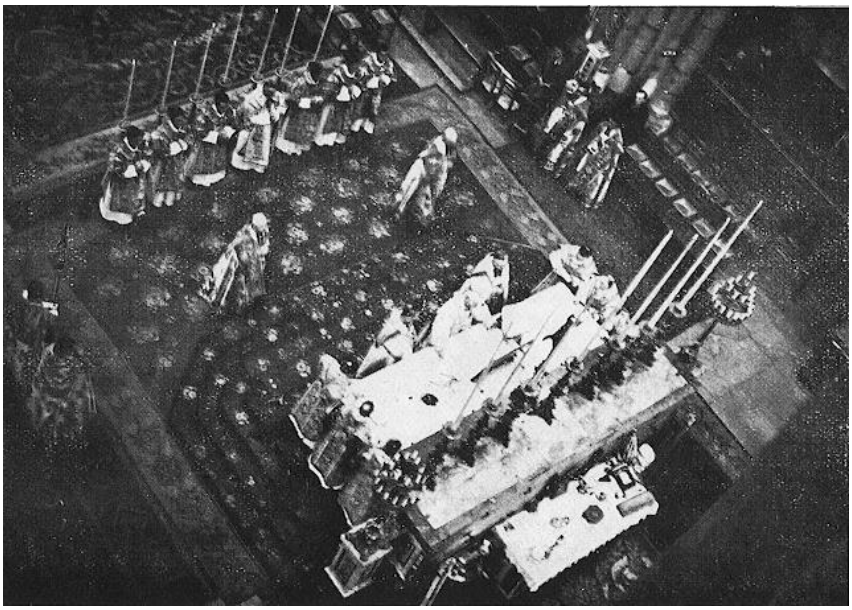
The chief acolyte now comes with the incense and presents it to the primate who proceeds to bless the incense. The incense is then placed within the thurible and the archbishop proceeds to incense the bread and wine, the cross and the top (mensa) of altar itself -- with the rest of the altar being incensed around its circumference by the Canon-Deacon using the full length of the chain according to the Lyonese rubrics -- and similar to how one sees incensations done in the Eastern liturgical rites. The Canon Deacon then incenses the archbishop and then proceeds to incenses the others in the sanctuary according to their rank, once again by means of full chain.

Proximate to all this taking place we can find a rather interesting ceremony, akin of the offering made to the pope by the canons of the Vatican Basilica at the conclusion of the solemn papal Mass, whereby the Primate, with the Canon Deacon and Subdeacon to either side holding a tray, receives an honorarium offering from his canons. Each of the canons come one-by-one before the archbishop, genuflect, kneel before the bishop, and kiss his ring, and then give their 'offering' of a coin to the archbishop which is placed on the tray held by the deacon and subdeacon.

The archbishop now purifies his fingers for the second time and continues the Offertory prayers bringing him to the Preface -- by which time the deacon has completed the incensations and lines up before the altar with the six other induti deacons. The six priests in their chasubles are by now at the altar, three on each side of the Archbishop.

The Sanctus and Canon of the Mass

At this point the archbishop chants the Preface of the Mass, at the conclusion of which the choir begins the Sanctus while the archbishop proceeds to pray the prayers of the Canon of the Mass -- the seven deacons lining up behind him according to their traditional function of "custodes" (guardians) of the bishop. Returning to our note about the use of incense in the primatial cathedral, it is at this point that, on great feasts, incense is replenished in the two large standing bowls contained on either side of the altar.



At the "plenu sunt caeli" during the Sanctus, the seven acolytes and six subdeacons form two lines at the foot of the altar near the entrance of the chancel. Four of the acolytes carry lighted torches while the other three hold their arms crossed before their breasts. These acolytes line up behind the seven induti deacons while the subdeacons line up to either side of the deacons, forming a line of thirteen sacred ministers -- the Canon Subdeacon to this point still being behind the altar with the paten.

The Canon-Subdeacon now emerges from behind the altar and stands to the right of the altar on the epistle side, still holding the paten in his maniple; all genuflect together toward the altar and kneel in preparation for the consecration. The Canon-Deacon proceeds up to the altar to kneel on the step near the primate to raise his chasuble at the elevations. (It is at this point that fresh incense is once again replenished in the large bowls to either side of the altar for the consecration).

At the conclusion of the second elevation after the consecration of the bread and the wine, the sacred ministers once again rise and genuflect; the Canon-Subdeacon returns to his position behind the altar.

Those who were behind the altar in the presbyterium now return there until the time of the Pater Noster, at which point they return to the foot of the altar. Unlike the traditional Roman rite, the archbishop will also pray, out loud, the "Libera nos" in accordance with the Lyonese usage (which is prayed silently in the Roman rite). The paten is now returned to the altar by the Canon-Subdeacon who kisses the archbishop's shoulder.

At this point in the Lyonese liturgy, instead of offering the "Pax Domini," the bishop will now once again cover the chalice and will give a unique pontifical blessing.

The Pontifical Blessing

This blessing is a remnant of the ancient Gallican liturgy which was retained in the Lyonese rite. There is some speculation that this blessing may have served as a dismissal for the non-communicants at the Mass. There are five prayers that form part of this pontifical blessing, two of which are variable by the feast, each coming with the response "Amen." The Canon-Deacon is given the archbishop's crozier and, turning toward the congregation, holds it aloft with both hands and sings, "Humiltate vos ad benedictionem" (exhorting the blessing be received in humility) to which is responded "Deo gratias." The archbishop then recites the prayers of the blessing while wearing his mitre and at the fourth prayer he is handed the crozier by the deacon, and he gives the pontifical blessing wearing the full insignia of his pontifical rank. At the conclusion of this blessing the archbishop then takes the particle of the consecrated Host that he had placed on the paten and chants "Et pax + quia si + semper vobis + cum" making the sign of the cross with the particle three times.

The blessing having been completed; the archbishop turns back to the altar.

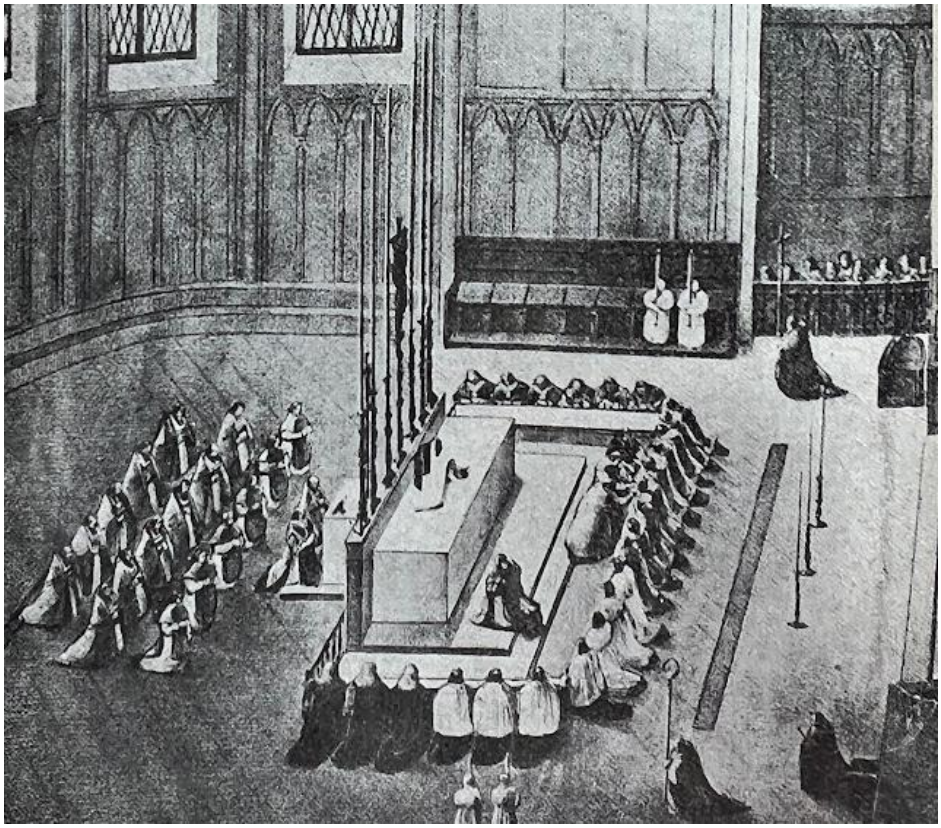
The Agnus Dei, Pax, and Communion

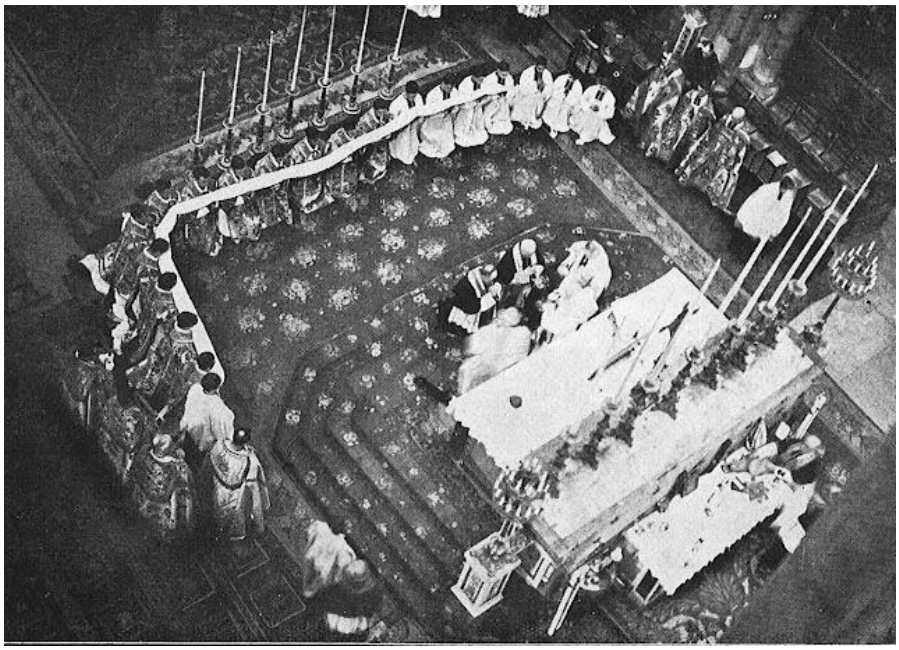
At this point of the rite, the choir begins to sing the Agnus Dei -- the first two versicles of which are sung on their knees; at the third and final versicle, they rise and stand. Between the first and second versicles is sung the "Venite, populi." It is perhaps worth noting that in the Lyonese form of the liturgy, there is no striking of the breast as in the Roman rite at the Agnus Dei. The portion of the Host that had been broken off is now dropped into the chalice to intermingle it with the Precious Blood like in the Roman rite.

At the conclusion of these prayers the archbishop is presented with the Pax tablet (also called the pax instrument or pax brede) by the Canon-Deacon, which he kisses as a means of passing the sign of peace. The deacon then kisses it in turn and places it back upon the altar. This is, in fact, the only time the kiss of peace is exchanged in the Lyonese rite - in the presence of the primate; otherwise, it is excluded.

The "Domine non sum dignus" (Lord, I am not worthy) is now recited and communion made by the archbishop. At this point those officiants who are not priests, but who are to take communion, join the line of the deacons before the altar, forming a semi-circle around the altar in preparation to receive communion. Together they genuflect and kneel around the balustrade surrounding the altar and a great communion cloth is spread out before them while they receive the Confiteor.

Communion is then distributed to them by the Archbishop -- offering each communicant his ring to kiss prior to reception of the Sacrament. Following the Archbishop is a chaplain who carries a chalice which is in turn offered to each communicant. This is not a case of communion under both kinds it should be noted, but is unconsecrated wine which is offered as a form of ablution or purification of the mouth following reception of the Blessed Sacrament. Each of the sacred ministers communicating take a sip and are offered a purificator to wipe their lips with.





The following image shows the Communion cloth; it is shown in the pre-1936 sanctuary arrangement went the balustrade around the altar had not yet been re-installed.

At the conclusion of the distribution of communion, if there are consecrated hosts remaining the Dean, wearing a cope and humeral veil, comes to the altar to receive the ciborium from the

archbishop. The archbishop solemnly kneels in reverence to the Sacrament and hands the ciborium to the Dean who, accompanied by a server who carries the ombrellino, four servers with lighted torches, priests vested in chasubles, other clerics in copes and the macebearer, process to the altar of the Blessed Sacrament to deposit them into the tabernacle.

The ablutions are completed by the archbishop at the altar while the choir sings the Communion antiphon. During the ablutions he offers the chalice, covered with paten, in horizontal/lateral motion, first to the deacon on his one side and then to the subdeacon on the other; both respectively kiss the knob on the chalice. The purified vessels are then returned to the altar of St. Speratus behind the high altar by the Canon-Subdeacon.

Post-Communion

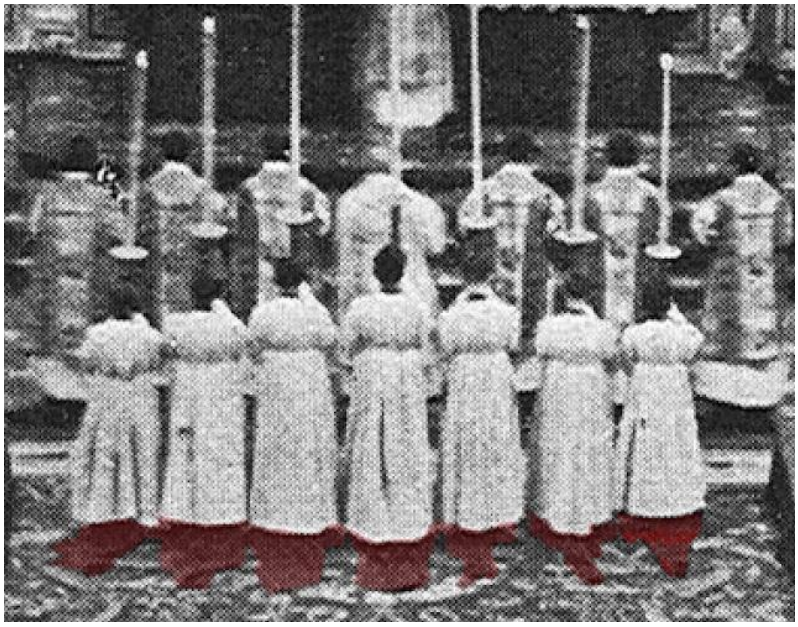
The sacred ministers having returned in procession from the tabernacle at the altar of the Blessed Sacrament and the archbishop having now returned to his episcopal throne, the post-communion prayers are now recited. The Canon Deacon of the Mass now sings the "Ite Missa est."

In some instances there may be a papal blessing and indulgence announced (done on Easter Sunday and one other solemn day of the liturgical year of the archbishop's choosing); if that is done, it is offered at this point of the liturgy, but otherwise the liturgy proceeds to the recitation of the Last Gospel while the various ranks of clergy being to process out as part of the recessional.

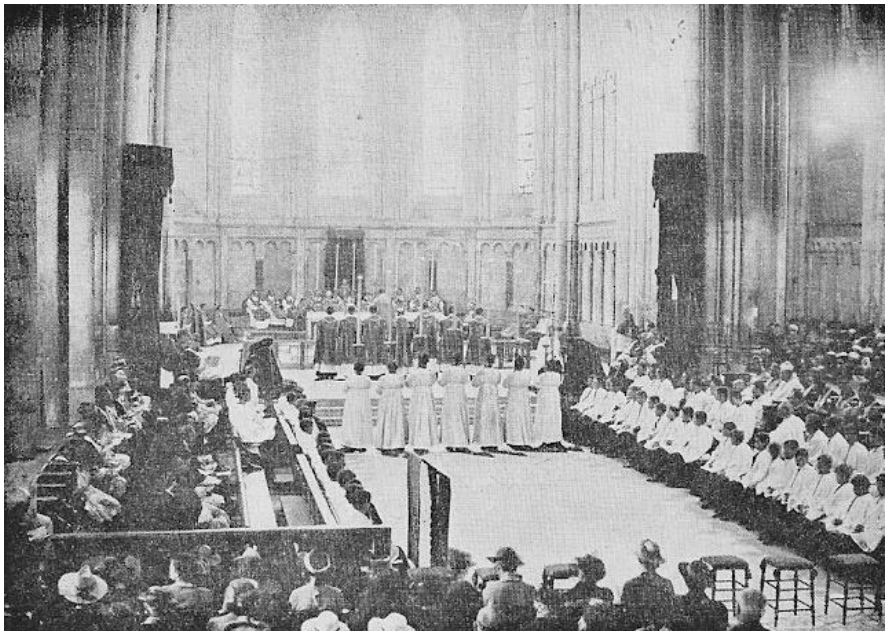
Other notes

One also sees within the Lyonese rite some distinctive vestural usages such as long-trained cassocks, not just for the Archbishop, but also for some of the other sacred ministers -- even the seven acolytes (see below) and the choristers. It is also worth noting that in the most solemn of occasions, the senior priest, deacon, and subdeacon were granted the privilege of wearing the mitre -- however Archdale King suggests that these were not mitres per se but rather a variation on the amice being worn on the head which took on a pointed appearance like the shape of the mitre proper.

Left and Middle, Mitred Subdeacon and Deacon; Right: Thurifer wearing the "ofroi" (deatched orphrey/clavi) over the alb



The seven acolytes seen wearing long-trained red cassocks with a girded alb over top



This may be a good time to also note that when the acolytes were not holding their seven candles (as shown above) they were left standing before the high altar -- much like how candles are left on the steps of the altar in some of the rites of the religious orders such as the Dominican rite.

In the Pontifical form of the Lyonese liturgy, the archbishop is also not attended by two deacons of honour but rather by two priests of honour vested in copes who carry a large gremial in the liturgical colour of the day before him (see the very first image illustrating this article above).

Further, except for the Offertory and Canon, the celebrant alone (in the case of the pontifical Mass, the archbishop) alone stands at the altar.

Finally, a general comment should be made about the use of incense in the rite. Unlike the Roman rite, the thurible is not used to incense the altar at the Kyrie, nor to incense the Sacred Species at the elevations. Instead, on great feast days in the primatial church two large standing urns are placed to either side of the altar.

These urns are replenished with fresh incense at the Asperges, the prayers at the foot of the altar, the Gloria, the Sanctus, and the elevations at the consecration. One can well imagine that it must have made for quite an impressive sight to see those two columns of smoke arising from either side of the high altar on these most solemn of occasions.

One might note that no chalice veil is used in the solemn form of the Lyonese liturgy (pontifical form or otherwise). Rather what one sees used here is a kind of ornamental covering, or canopy, that is placed over the chalice.

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